Contact

www.linkedin.com/in/riki-ellison (LinkedIn)
www.missiledefenseadvocacy.org (Company)
www.youthimpactprogram.org (Company)

Top Skills

Non-profits
Sports
Social Media

Riki Ellison

Chairman & Founder at Missile Defense Advocacy Alliance and Youth Impact Program
Alexandria, Virginia, United States

Summary

Mr. Riki Ellison is the Founder and Chairman of the Missile Defense Advocacy Alliance; a non-profit organization launched in 2002 with a singular purpose and mission to drive for the deployment, development, and evolution of missile defense. Mr. Ellison has been involved with missile defense since 1980, being introduced to it by then Governor Ronald Reagan's Senior Defense Advisor, Dr. William R. Van Cleave and Dr. Edward Teller. Mr. Ellison has been in attendance of over 296 missile defense tests, visited 801 U.S. and allied missile defense bases.

Mr. Ellison established the annual U.S. and Allied "Missile Defender of the Year Award Ceremony." There have been 82 Defender of the Year events hosted in eight countries that have recognized 1,016 Awardees from 22 different nations since 2011.

Mr. Ellison and MDAA created three academic University programs in partnership with the University of Southern California's SHIELD Executive Program, the University of Arizona AETOS Executive Program and the University of Hawaii's ARTEMIS Executive Program.

In 2006, Mr. Ellison founded the Youth Impact Program for disadvantaged and at-risk youth in our nation's inner cities. There have been 52 Youth Impact Programs in 16 of our nation's major cities and major universities. YIP has impacted 4,115 at-risk youth, 839 NCAA athletes, 169 public school teachers, 403 U.S. Marines, U.S. Army Soldiers, and U.S. Air Force Airmen. Students who attended our 2024 programs on average increased their Stem scores by 40%, language art scores by 27%, and mathematics by 22%.

In 2011, Mr. Ellison brought the National Football League and the United States Army together on traumatic brain injury that resulted

in a partnership announced in 2012 by the Commissioner of the NFL and the Chief of the United States Army.

Earlier in his career, Mr. Ellison played professional football for 7 years as a starting middle linebacker with the San Francisco 49ers and 3 years with the Las Vegas Raiders, winning three Super Bowl championships in 1984, 1988 and 1989. He was the first New Zealander and the first Maori to play in the NFL and the first New Zealander to win a Super Bowl. Mr. Ellison was inducted into the Polynesian Football Hall of Fame in 2017 and the New Zealand Māori Sports Hall of Fame in 2024. Ellison played college football at the University of Southern California, winning a National Championship and two Rose Bowl Championships following a State High School Football Championship in Arizona.

Experience

Missile Defense Advocacy Alliance
Chairman and Founder
September 2002 - Present (23 years 10 months)

The MDAA mission is to make the world safe by advocating for the development and deployment of missile defense systems to defend the United States and its allies against missile threats.

The MDAA is the only organization in its existence whose primary mission is to recruit, organize and mobilize proponents to advocate for the critical need of missile defense. We are a non-partisan membership-based and membership funded organization that does not advocate on behalf of any specific system, technology, architecture, or entity.

Youth Impact Program
Chairman & Founder
May 2005 - Present (21 years 2 months)

Chairman & Founder of the Youth Impact Program. A summer program founded by Mr. Ellison which has completed 49 programs in 15 cities across the national with NCAA Universities to help disadvantaged youth from inner cities improve their overall life and socialization skills, along with athletic skills and academic performance.

Las Vegas Raiders
Middle Linebacker
April 1990 - March 1993 (3 years)

San Francisco 49ers
Middle Linebacker
1983 - 1990 (7 years)

Education

The United States Army War College
· (July 2022 - July 2022)

University of Southern California
Graduate Certificate Program, Defense and Strategic Studies · (September 1981 - May 1983)

University of Southern California
B.A., International Relations and Affairs · (1978 - 1983)

University of Notre Dame
Business Management and Entrepreneurial Program · (2013)

Air War College
National Security · (2011)